

Dire predictions

When the [first](#) modern industries were established at the end of the 18th century, it seemed as if there were no limits to the things they could produce. There was an apparently infinite supply of natural resources such as coal and iron for the new industries, and even farms became more productive with increased mechanization.

As societies became richer, they consumed more, and industry satisfied the demand by supplying more goods. There was no reason to believe that this continual improvement in living standards would ever end. Even then, though, some economists had doubts. Robert Malthus, for example, warned that populations were also increasing, and that in time their rate of consumption could outstrip supply. Through the 19th and 20th centuries, his warnings looked pessimistic, but in the 21st century world population has risen drastically, increasing demand for essential resources. It's also become clearer that we live on a planet that has finite resources, and that we'll have to reduce our consumption of them. There's a limit to the amount of land that can be used to produce food, for example, and to the supply of fresh water. But it's not only food that we consume. Our lifestyles have created a demand for manufactured goods, energy, and transportation that puts pressure on supplies of resources such as coal, gas, oil, and minerals that can never be replaced.